

Yucheng Jin

Prof. Holguin

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*The Sun Also Rises*: Silent Renewal of the “Lost Generation”

What a story does Ernest Hemingway, the lucky yet unfortunate survivor of World War I, want to tell by *The Sun Also Rises*? Since the day when this novel was first published, readers have never arrived at a consensus. Some people believe that nihilism is the essence of *The Sun Also Rises*, as almost every character indulges in drunkenness and promiscuity like bone-deep addictions—after all, the meaning of life seems blurred and plain, because “nobody ever lives their life all the way up except bullfighters” (Hemingway, p. 6). For the majority of the people, they just monotonously repeat what they had done yesterday and wait for tomorrow’s sunrise. I acknowledge the value of this view, but from my perspective, nihilism just reflects the tip of the iceberg, what Hemingway actually wants to express in *The Sun Also Rises* is the silent renewal of the “lost generation”, who experienced profound suffering and witnessed catastrophic destruction of the unnecessary World War, and whose life has to go on over the ruins of the old time. For them, temporary escape could help relieve their distress, but only resolved resistance to the “fake European standards” (p. 60) and the faith of “never be daunted” (p. 38) may bring renewal. In this response paper, I will especially focus on the epiphany of Brett to reveal why the renewal of the “lost generation” is the theme of Hemingway’s maiden work of novel creation.

As the female protagonist of *The Sun Also Rises*, Brett, or Lady Ashley, surprisingly, is often accused of being frivolous. In front of this “damned good-looking” (p. 12) lady, no men

could get away from being fascinated by her beauty and personality, and Brett is also enjoying the pursuits of different men—she even admits that sometimes she “do feel (myself) such a bitch” (p. 96). However, the dissolute side of Brett is just on the surface, like a cup of brandy that eases her unspeakable pains. From the bottom of her heart, Brett is not the kind of women who love vanity—if so, why she sends the rich and powerful count for champagne as if he were her servant? To some extent, Brett’s unrestrained love is just a bitter choice for her to regain her long-awaited true love, after all, she has nothing to lose. During the wartime, she “was a V. A. D in a hospital” and “her own true love had just kicked off with the dysentery” (p. 20), although Hemingway does not explicitly describe her tragic romance, from Robert Cohn’s remark, that “I (Cohn) don’t believe she would marry anybody she didn’t love” (p. 21), we know that the death of her first love marks the beginning of her misery. Later, Brett marries Lord Ashley, but this marriage proves to be an absolute nightmare, because “(Ashley) Always made Brett sleep on the floor. Finally, when he got really bad, he used to tell her he’d kill her.” (p. 107), and Brett completely loses her dignity as a wife. After divorce, she falls in love with Mike Campbell and Jake Barnes, however, fate gives her another joke: Mike is an underdog who goes from bankruptcy to bankruptcy “gradually and then suddenly” (p. 72), and Jake could not give her sexual satisfaction.

Before the unexpected encounter with the young and masculine matador, Pedro Romero, despite all the suffering, Brett never gives up her unrelenting search for true love. To some extent, although sometimes Brett might abuse alcohol to relieve sadness and question herself about her relationship with Jake, she is always a dauntless fighter and brave rebel against the old doctrines, who battles with the unfair fate silently yet determinedly. But the real test does not come until she realizes Romero’s infatuation—as Brett astonishingly finds out that the nineteen-

year-old youth “really wanted to marry me, so I couldn't go away from him” (p. 127), she begins to fear, because she is no longer young, and from the bottom of her heart, she could not accept to “be one of these bitches that ruins children” (p. 127). At this point, Brett finally discovers that without the companionship of Jake, she “had such a hell of a time” (p. 126), and the true love she’s long looking for after her first lover’s death is just Jake, with whom they have experienced wonderful past, and “could have had such a damned good time together” (p. 129) in the future. Eventually, Brett understands that to let go is also a way of saying I love you, because the greatest gift she can give for her loved one, is to restrain her desire that may hurt. Therefore, when reunites with Jake, for the first time, she tells him “don’t get drunk”, because “you don’t have to” (p. 129).

In conclusion, fortunately, at the end of the story, Brett and Jake both find that the key to a new chapter of their life, is nothing but the companion of each other, which forms the foundation of their years to come, over the ruins of the war. So far, the two once lost souls have found an inspiring renewed life direction, thus with a knowingly smell, Hemingway stops his writing, despite the story of Brett, Jake, and the “lost generation”, is still unfinished.

### References

- [1] Hemingway, Ernest. *The Sun Also Rises*. Web. <<http://www.swornfriends.com/Common-/ueditor/net/upload/51/2013-06-25/8AEEC875B34240AD.pdf>>. Accessed 26 May 2020.